

PREHISTORY TO 600CE

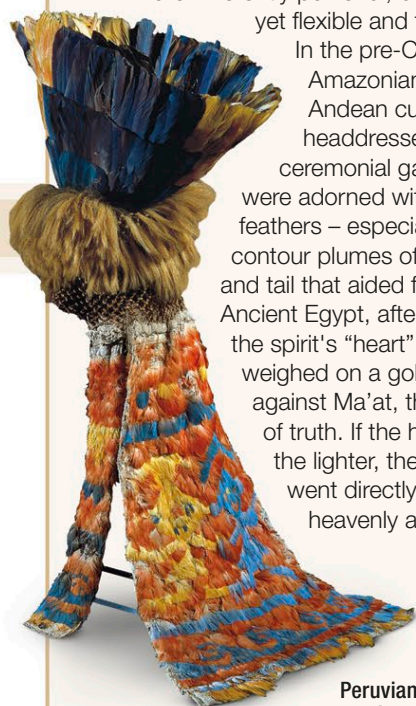
PROWESS AND PROTECTION

In some parts of the ancient world, men spent much of their lives away from home on active military service. What they wore depended to a large extent on money and rank. Men who dressed in armour were likely to have paid for it themselves – like the hoplites (Greek foot soldiers) in the 5th century BCE, who were drawn from the middle classes and could afford to provide their own body protection. Early armour included metal plates, scales, hardened leather, and padded linen. The invention of mail shirts, made from individually forged interlocking rings, is attributed to the Celts in about 300 BCE. Chain was expensive to produce, and was probably restricted to the highest ranking warriors. A mail shirt allowed more limb movement than some other forms of protection, but at 15kg (30lb) it weighed the wearer down. Battledress styles sometimes depended on attitude – the fearless Spartans marched to war in red capes to disguise bloodstains.

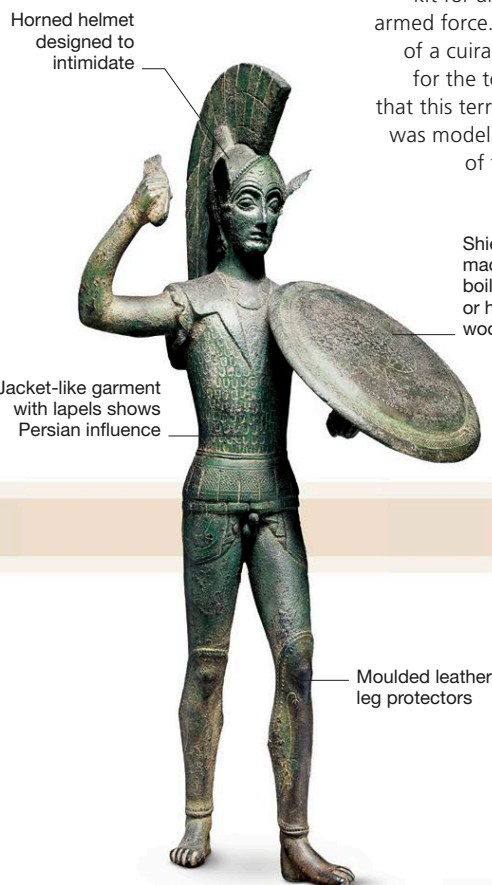
PROTECTIVE FEATHERS

Getting closer to the gods and gaining protection from evil by wearing plumes, or representations of birds, is common in many cultures, from Egypt to Peru. Feathers are inherently powerful, being light, yet flexible and tough.

In the pre-Columbian Amazonian and Andean cultures, headdresses and ceremonial garments were adorned with feathers – especially the contour plumes of wing and tail that aided flight. In Ancient Egypt, after death, the spirit's "heart" was weighed on a golden scale against Ma'at, the feather of truth. If the heart was the lighter, the spirit went directly to the heavenly afterlife.



Peruvian feathered headdress



Jacket-like garment with lapels shows Persian influence

Moulded leather leg protectors

Bronze warrior This 5th-century BCE votive figure from the Etruscan civilization may represent Mars, god of war. Soldiers held their shields on the left side, overlapping them when in line to create a wall of defence.

Pattern on helmet gives illusion of fierce expression

Felted wool hood protected head, neck, and shoulders

Distinctive crest served as marker on battlefield

Ancient Greek soldier

A helmet was the basic kit for any rank of an armed force. The absence of a cuirass (protection for the torso) suggests that this terracotta figurine was modelled on a soldier of the lower ranks.

Shield would be made of metal, boiled leather, or hide over a wooden frame

